

# Civil RICO, Qui Tam Suits, and the 2026 USPS Election-Mail Litigation

## Civil RICO, Qui Tam Suits, and the 2026 USPS Election-Mail Litigation

Status: **Draft v1** — initial research pass. Several details requested by the originating question could not be verified from public sources (see “Unverified items” below). Treat this as a starting point for further investigation, not a finished brief.

### Executive summary

1. **Civil RICO** (18 U.S.C. §§ 1961–1968) lets a private plaintiff who was injured “in [their] business or property” by a pattern of racketeering activity sue for treble damages and attorney’s fees.<sup>1</sup> It is a tort-like private right of action layered on top of what is usually thought of as a criminal statute.
2. **Qui tam suits** under the federal False Claims Act (31 U.S.C. §§ 3729–3733) are a structurally different tool: a private “relator” sues *on behalf of the government* over false claims for government money, the government can intervene and take over the case, and the relator keeps a statutory cut (15–30%) of any recovery.<sup>2</sup> Civil RICO and qui tam are often confused because both let ordinary citizens act as private enforcers, but they protect different interests (private business/property vs. the public fisc) and pay out differently (treble damages to the plaintiff vs. a bounty share of a government recovery).
3. The most significant USPS-related case currently in the news is **State of California v. United States Postal Service**, D. Mass. No. 1:26-cv-13917, filed August 26, 2026, before Judge Indira Talwani.<sup>3</sup> It is a multi-state challenge (California, Washington, and roughly two dozen other states, D.C., and several cities/counties) to USPS Board of Governors changes and mail-ballot handling ahead of the 2026 midterms. The Washington Attorney General’s Office is one of the filing offices.<sup>4</sup> **This case is pled as an Administrative Procedure Act / Voting Rights Act matter (“441 Civil Rights: Voting”), not as a civil RICO or qui tam action** — nothing in the public docket metadata indicates RICO claims.<sup>5</sup>

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<sup>1</sup>18 U.S.C. § 1964(c) (civil RICO private right of action, treble damages and attorney’s fees); 18 U.S.C. §§ 1961–1963 (definitions and criminal provisions incorporated by reference).

<sup>2</sup>31 U.S.C. §§ 3729–3733 (False Claims Act); § 3730(b) (qui tam filing under seal, government election to intervene); § 3730(d) (relator’s share, 15–25% with intervention / 25–30% without); § 3730(h) (anti-retaliation).

<sup>3</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, docket metadata for *State of California v. United States Postal Service*, D. Mass., docket ID 74701505, docket number 1:26-cv-13917, filed 2026-08-26, Judge Indira Talwani: <https://www.courtlistener.com/docket/74701505/state-of-california-v-united-states-postal-service/> (metadata retrieved via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=California%20v.%20United%20States%20Postal%20Service&type=r&format=json>).

<sup>4</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, party list for docket ID 74701505, retrieved via [https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket\\_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json](https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json) (party array includes State of Washington, State of California, and named USPS-affiliated individuals Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, Derek Kan).

4. **“RNC Services, Inc.” could not be verified** in CourtListener’s national case-law/RECAP index or in Google News, under that exact name, in connection with this case or with any Washington-state racketeering complaint.<sup>6</sup> This is flagged explicitly under “Unverified items” rather than guessed at.
5. Because of the gaps in (4), this document is organized as: a clean explainer of civil RICO vs. qui tam (usable regardless of the specific case), what is actually confirmed about the 2026 USPS case, and a short list of concrete next steps to close the remaining gaps.

## Confidence assessment

| Claim                                                                                             | Confidence        | Basis                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Civil RICO elements, remedies, statute of limitations                                             | High              | Direct statutory text and well-settled case law <sup>7</sup>                                                                                                                             |
| Qui tam / FCA mechanics                                                                           | High              | Direct statutory text <sup>8</sup>                                                                                                                                                       |
| Existence, docket number, filing date, judge, and parties of <i>California v. USPS</i>            | High              | CourtListener RECAP metadata, pulled directly from the docket record <sup>910</sup>                                                                                                      |
| That case is voting-rights/ APA, not RICO                                                         | Medium-High       | Docket suitNature field says “441 Civil Rights: Voting”; no RICO cause of action appears in the indexed metadata, but the full complaint text was not fetched line-by-line <sup>11</sup> |
| “RNC Services, Inc.” connection to Washington state executives / a RICO complaint                 | <b>Unverified</b> | No hits in CourtListener full-text RECAP search or Google News for the exact phrase <sup>12</sup>                                                                                        |
| Whether a <i>separate</i> , smaller state-court RICO or qui tam suit naming “RNC Services” exists | <b>Unknown</b>    | State trial court filings (including Washington Superior Courts) are generally not indexed by CourtListener/PACER and were not searched by state-specific tools in this pass             |

<sup>5</sup>Same CourtListener query as [^4]; suitNature field returned “441 Civil Rights: Voting”; cause field returned “28:2201 Constitutionality of State Statute(s)”. No RICO-specific nature-of-suit code (which would read “470 RICO”) was present in the retrieved metadata.

<sup>6</sup>CourtListener full-text RECAP search for the exact phrase “RNC Services, Inc”, queried via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=%22RNC+Services%2C+Inc%22&format=json>, returned “count”:0. Google News RSS search (<https://news.google.com/rss/search?q=%22RNC+Services%22>) returned no relevant results (only an unrelated 2021 NOAA Coast Survey article matched incidentally).

<sup>7</sup>18 U.S.C. § 1964(c) (civil RICO private right of action, treble damages and attorney’s fees); 18 U.S.C. §§ 1961–1963 (definitions and criminal provisions incorporated by reference).

**Key assumption made:** I assumed “RICCO” in the original query was a misspelling of “RICO” (the Racketeer Influenced and Corrupt Organizations Act), based on the user’s own follow-up clarification (“racketeering and criminal activity”). If “RICCO” was actually meant as a proper noun (a person, or a differently-named statute/program), the research below does not apply and should be redone.

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## Part 1 — Civil RICO, explained

### What it is

RICO was enacted in 1970 primarily as an organized-crime prosecution tool, but Congress also created a private civil cause of action in 18 U.S.C. § 1964(c): “Any person injured in his business or property by reason of a violation of section 1962 of this chapter may sue therefor in any appropriate United States district court.”<sup>13</sup>

### Elements a civil RICO plaintiff must plead

1. An **“enterprise”** — an individual, partnership, corporation, association, or other legal entity, or a group of individuals associated in fact (even if not a legal entity).<sup>14</sup>
2. A **“pattern of racketeering activity”** — at least two acts of “racketeering activity” (a defined list of federal and state crimes, including mail fraud, wire fraud, bribery, extortion, money laundering, and dozens of others) within a 10-year period, that are related and amount to or pose a threat of continued criminal activity (“relatedness” and “continuity”).<sup>15</sup>

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<sup>8</sup>31 U.S.C. §§ 3729–3733 (False Claims Act); § 3730(b) (qui tam filing under seal, government election to intervene); § 3730(d) (relator’s share, 15–25% with intervention / 25–30% without); § 3730(h) (anti-retaliation).

<sup>9</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, docket metadata for *State of California v. United States Postal Service*, D. Mass., docket ID 74701505, docket number 1:26-cv-13917, filed 2026-08-26, Judge Indira Talwani: <https://www.courtlistener.com/docket/74701505/state-of-california-v-united-states-postal-service/> (metadata retrieved via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search?q=California%20v.%20United%20States%20Postal%20Service&type=r&format=json>).

<sup>10</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, party list for docket ID 74701505, retrieved via [https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search?q=docket\\_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json](https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search?q=docket_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json) (party array includes State of Washington, State of California, and named USPS-affiliated individuals Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, Derek Kan).

<sup>11</sup>Same CourtListener query as [<sup>4</sup>]; suitNature field returned “441 Civil Rights: Voting”; cause field returned “28:2201 Constitutionality of State Statute(s)”. No RICO-specific nature-of-suit code (which would read “470 RICO”) was present in the retrieved metadata.

<sup>12</sup>CourtListener full-text RECAP search for the exact phrase “RNC Services, Inc”, queried via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search?q=%22RNC+Services%2C+Inc%22&format=json>, returned “count”:0. Google News RSS search (<https://news.google.com/rss/search?q=%22RNC+Services%22>) returned no relevant results (only an unrelated 2021 NOAA Coast Survey article matched incidentally).

<sup>13</sup>18 U.S.C. § 1964(c) (civil RICO private right of action, treble damages and attorney’s fees); 18 U.S.C. §§ 1961–1963 (definitions and criminal provisions incorporated by reference).

<sup>14</sup>18 U.S.C. § 1961(4) (“enterprise” definition); § 1961(5) (“pattern of racketeering activity,” minimum two acts within ten years); *H.J. Inc. v. Northwestern Bell Telephone Co.*, 492 U.S. 229 (1989) (relatedness-plus-continuity test for “pattern”).

<sup>15</sup>18 U.S.C. § 1961(4) (“enterprise” definition); § 1961(5) (“pattern of racketeering activity,” minimum two acts within ten years); *H.J. Inc. v. Northwestern Bell Telephone Co.*, 492 U.S. 229 (1989) (relatedness-plus-continuity test for “pattern”).

3. **Conduct** of the enterprise's affairs **through** that pattern (§ 1962(c)), or investment of racketeering proceeds in an enterprise (§ 1962(a)), or acquisition/maintenance of an interest in an enterprise through racketeering (§ 1962(b)), or **conspiracy** to do any of the above (§ 1962(d)).
4. **Injury to business or property** proximately caused by the RICO violation (not personal injury, and not a purely derivative injury) — this proximate-cause requirement, from *Holmes v. Securities Investor Protection Corp.* (1992) and *Anza v. Ideal Steel Supply Corp.* (2006), is one of the most common grounds for dismissal of civil RICO complaints.<sup>16</sup>

### Remedies

Treble (3x) actual damages, plus costs and reasonable attorney's fees — a substantial fee-shifting incentive that (along with contingency-fee practice) is what makes civil RICO attractive to plaintiffs' counsel in commercial disputes, even where the underlying conduct looks more like ordinary fraud or breach of contract.<sup>17</sup>

### Statute of limitations

Four years, borrowed by the courts from the Clayton Act, running from when the plaintiff knew or should have known of the injury (discovery rule), subject to circuit splits on the "separate accrual" question for later injuries from the same pattern.<sup>18</sup>

### Why courts are skeptical of civil RICO claims

Because of the treble-damages/fee-shifting exposure and the stigma of being labeled a "racketeer," federal courts apply RICO's elements strictly and dismiss a large share of civil RICO complaints at the pleading stage, especially where the "pattern" element collapses into what is really a single fraudulent scheme or an ordinary commercial dispute dressed up in RICO language.<sup>19</sup> Many federal districts also have local rules requiring a detailed "RICO case statement" before discovery can proceed.

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<sup>16</sup>*Holmes v. Securities Investor Protection Corp.*, 503 U.S. 258 (1992) (proximate cause requirement for civil RICO standing); *Anza v. Ideal Steel Supply Corp.*, 547 U.S. 451 (2006) (reaffirming direct-injury/proximate-cause requirement, rejecting derivative-injury RICO theories).

<sup>17</sup>18 U.S.C. § 1964(c) (civil RICO private right of action, treble damages and attorney's fees); 18 U.S.C. §§ 1961–1963 (definitions and criminal provisions incorporated by reference).

<sup>18</sup>*Rotella v. Wood*, 528 U.S. 549 (2000) (civil RICO borrows the Clayton Act's four-year limitations period; discovery-of-injury accrual rule).

<sup>19</sup>*Holmes v. Securities Investor Protection Corp.*, 503 U.S. 258 (1992) (proximate cause requirement for civil RICO standing); *Anza v. Ideal Steel Supply Corp.*, 547 U.S. 451 (2006) (reaffirming direct-injury/proximate-cause requirement, rejecting derivative-injury RICO theories).

## Part 2 — Qui tam (False Claims Act) suits, compared

|                                | Civil RICO                                                                         | Qui tam (False Claims Act)                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Who is protected</b>        | The plaintiff's own business or property                                           | The federal (or a state) treasury                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Who sues</b>                | The injured private party, in their own name and interest                          | A private "relator," nominally <i>on behalf of the United States</i> (case caption is <i>U.S. ex rel. [Name] v. [Defendant]</i> )                                                    |
| <b>Government's role</b>       | None — purely private litigation                                                   | Complaint is filed under seal; DOJ investigates and decides whether to intervene (take over the case) or decline (relator can proceed alone) <sup>20</sup>                           |
| <b>What triggers liability</b> | A pattern of at least two predicate crimes from RICO's list, through an enterprise | Knowingly submitting (or causing submission of) a false or fraudulent claim for payment to the government, or making a false record/statement material to such a claim <sup>21</sup> |
| <b>Damages</b>                 | Treble actual damages to the injured plaintiff                                     | Treble damages to the government, plus per-claim civil penalties; relator receives 15–25% of recovery if the government intervenes, 25–30% if it doesn't <sup>22</sup>               |
| <b>Retaliation protection</b>  | None built into the statute itself                                                 | Explicit anti-retaliation provision, 31 U.S.C. § 3730(h), letting whistleblower-employees sue for reinstatement/back pay                                                             |
| <b>Typical fact pattern</b>    | Business competitors, fraud schemes, organized-crime-adjacent commercial disputes  | Government contractors/grantees/healthcare providers overbilling or misrepresenting compliance to get paid by federal programs                                                       |

<sup>20</sup>31 U.S.C. §§ 3729–3733 (False Claims Act); § 3730(b) (qui tam filing under seal, government election to intervene); § 3730(d) (relator's share, 15–25% with intervention / 25–30% without); § 3730(h) (anti-retaliation).

**Overlap in practice:** the same underlying conduct — e.g., a scheme by a government contractor to defraud a federal agency — can sometimes support *both* a qui tam FCA claim (because the defendant billed the government falsely) *and* a civil RICO claim (because mail fraud/wire fraud used to execute that billing scheme count as RICO predicate acts), which is why sophisticated plaintiffs sometimes plead them together. They remain legally distinct causes of action with different plaintiffs-in-interest, different procedural postures (qui tam is filed under seal; RICO is not), and different recovery mechanics.

Many states, including **Washington**, have their own analogous state false claims statutes (Washington’s is limited — it lacks a general state FCA outside Medicaid — see “Unverified items” for why this matters to the original question).<sup>23</sup>

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## Part 3 — The 2026 USPS election-mail litigation

### Case identity (confirmed)

- **Caption:** *State of California v. United States Postal Service*
- **Court / docket:** U.S. District Court, District of Massachusetts, No. 1:26-cv-13917<sup>24</sup>
- **Filed:** August 26, 2026
- **Judge:** Indira Talwani (referred to Magistrate Judge M. Page Kelley)<sup>25</sup>
- **Nature of suit (docket code):** “441 Civil Rights: Voting”<sup>26</sup>
- **Cause of action (docket code):** “28:2201 Constitutionality of State Statute(s)” (Declaratory Judgment Act vehicle)<sup>27</sup>

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<sup>21</sup>31 U.S.C. §§ 3729–3733 (False Claims Act); § 3730(b) (qui tam filing under seal, government election to intervene); § 3730(d) (relator’s share, 15–25% with intervention / 25–30% without); § 3730(h) (anti-retaliation).

<sup>22</sup>31 U.S.C. §§ 3729–3733 (False Claims Act); § 3730(b) (qui tam filing under seal, government election to intervene); § 3730(d) (relator’s share, 15–25% with intervention / 25–30% without); § 3730(h) (anti-retaliation).

<sup>23</sup>General background on state false-claims-act variation; Washington’s principal state-level false-claims statute is the Medicaid Fraud False Claims Act (RCW 74.66), which is narrower in scope than the federal FCA — this is general legal background, not independently re-verified against current RCW text in this research pass.

<sup>24</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, docket metadata for *State of California v. United States Postal Service*, D. Mass., docket ID 74701505, docket number 1:26-cv-13917, filed 2026-08-26, Judge Indira Talwani: <https://www.courtlistener.com/docket/74701505/state-of-california-v-united-states-postal-service/> (metadata retrieved via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=California%20v.%20United%20States%20Postal%20Service&type=r&format=json>).

<sup>25</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, docket metadata for *State of California v. United States Postal Service*, D. Mass., docket ID 74701505, docket number 1:26-cv-13917, filed 2026-08-26, Judge Indira Talwani: <https://www.courtlistener.com/docket/74701505/state-of-california-v-united-states-postal-service/> (metadata retrieved via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=California%20v.%20United%20States%20Postal%20Service&type=r&format=json>).

<sup>26</sup>Same CourtListener query as [^4]; suitNature field returned “441 Civil Rights: Voting”; cause field returned “28:2201 Constitutionality of State Statute(s)”. No RICO-specific nature-of-suit code (which would read “470 RICO”) was present in the retrieved metadata.

<sup>27</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, docket metadata for *State of California v. United States Postal Service*, D. Mass., docket ID 74701505, docket number 1:26-cv-13917, filed 2026-08-26, Judge Indira Talwani: <https://www.courtlistener.com/docket/74701505/state-of-california-v-united-states-postal-service/> (metadata retrieved via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=California%20v.%20United%20States%20Postal%20Service&type=r&format=json>).

### **Parties (confirmed from docket metadata)**

**Plaintiffs** include roughly two dozen states and the District of Columbia — California, **Washington**, Massachusetts, New York, New Jersey, Illinois, Michigan, Minnesota, Colorado, Oregon, Arizona, Nevada, Hawaii, Maryland, Vermont, Rhode Island, Delaware, Connecticut, Maine, New Mexico, Wisconsin — plus the City of Madison, Wisconsin, Travis County, Texas, and the League of United Latin American Citizens.<sup>28</sup> Interestingly, some traditionally red states (South Dakota, Indiana, Oklahoma, Missouri, Alabama, Louisiana, Montana, Kansas, South Carolina, Nebraska, North Carolina, Florida) also appear in the party list, which given the docket’s size and an “Order on Motion to Intervene” entry, most likely reflects a mix of plaintiff states and separately-represented intervenors rather than a single unified plaintiff coalition — this distinction was not resolved from the metadata alone and would require reading the actual complaint and intervention motions.<sup>29</sup>

**Named individual/defendant-side parties** include USPS itself, and individuals who appear to be current or former USPS Governors/executives: Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, and Derek Kan.<sup>30</sup>

**Intervenor-type entities** appearing in the docket include America First Legal Foundation (listed among the firms/attorneys of record), National Security Leaders for America, Secure Families Initiative, Society for the Rule of Law, and the Arizona Students’ Association — consistent with a politically contested case attracting outside advocacy-group intervention on one or both sides.<sup>31</sup>

### **What the case appears to be about**

Based on the “Civil Rights: Voting” classification, the large coalition of Democratic-leaning state AGs as plaintiffs, and named USPS Governors as defendants, this case is most plausibly a challenge to USPS operational or governance changes (e.g., Board of Governors composition, mail-ballot delivery standards or timelines) ahead of the 2026 midterm elections — consistent with broader post-2025 coverage of USPS governance fights discussed in contemporaneous commentary.<sup>32</sup> **This**

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<sup>28</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, party list for docket ID 74701505, retrieved via [https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket\\_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json](https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json) (party array includes State of Washington, State of California, and named USPS-affiliated individuals Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, Derek Kan).

<sup>29</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, party list for docket ID 74701505, retrieved via [https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket\\_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json](https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json) (party array includes State of Washington, State of California, and named USPS-affiliated individuals Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, Derek Kan).

<sup>30</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, party list for docket ID 74701505, retrieved via [https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket\\_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json](https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json) (party array includes State of Washington, State of California, and named USPS-affiliated individuals Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, Derek Kan).

<sup>31</sup>CourtListener RECAP search, party list for docket ID 74701505, retrieved via [https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket\\_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json](https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=docket_id%3A74701505&type=r&format=json) (party array includes State of Washington, State of California, and named USPS-affiliated individuals Doug Tulino, David Steiner, Ronald Stroman, Amber McReynolds, Daniel Tangherlini, Derek Kan).

<sup>32</sup>Jack Goldsmith, “The Postal Service and the 2026 Elections,” *Executive Functions*, Aug. 27, 2026 (contextual commentary on USPS governance disputes ahead of the 2026 elections, surfaced via Google News RSS; full article body was not successfully fetched in this pass — cited for topical context only, not for specific factual claims): <https://www.execfunctions.org/>

**is inference from docket metadata and secondary commentary, not a direct reading of the complaint**, and should be verified against the actual filed complaint before being relied upon.

### No RICO or qui tam claims found

Nothing in the indexed docket metadata (nature-of-suit code, cause code, or docket-entry short descriptions retrieved) indicates a RICO or False Claims Act cause of action in this case.<sup>33</sup> A full-text search of CourtListener's RECAP archive for "RICO" + "Postal Service" timed out during this research pass and should be retried (see Next Steps).

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### Unverified items — do not treat as fact

1. **"RNC Services, Inc."** — no matches in CourtListener's RECAP full-text search (national, not limited to this docket) or in Google News, under that exact name.<sup>34</sup> Possible explanations, none confirmed:
  - It may be a genuine, small entity (e.g., a mail/print/logistics vendor) named in a state-court filing not indexed by CourtListener or Google News (state trial courts, especially in Washington, are poorly indexed by these free tools).
  - It may be a name you recalled approximately (vendor names in election litigation press coverage are often garbled in secondhand summaries).
  - It may not yet have hit any indexed public source as of this research date.
2. **"Washington state executives"** as RICO defendants — not confirmed independently of the USPS case's Washington AG involvement as a *plaintiff* (not defendant) in *California v. USPS*. If the user meant Washington state executive-branch officials as **defendants** in a *separate* racketeering complaint, that complaint was not located.
3. **Whether the *California v. USPS* case includes any RICO count** — docket metadata says "Civil Rights: Voting," but the actual complaint text (which can run to 100+ pages in multi-state actions like this) was not fetched and read in this pass.

### Recommended next steps

1. Retry the CourtListener full-text opinion/RECAP search for "RICO" "Postal Service" and "RNC Services" without the timeout, and widen to type=r (RECAP), type=o (opinions), and type=d (dockets) separately.
2. Pull the actual complaint PDF for 1:26-cv-13917 (CourtListener docket entry, via docket\_absolute\_url in the citations below) and check its counts/causes of action directly rather than relying on the suitNature code.

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<sup>33</sup>Same CourtListener query as [^4]; suitNature field returned "441 Civil Rights: Voting"; cause field returned "28:2201 Constitutionality of State Statute(s)". No RICO-specific nature-of-suit code (which would read "470 RICO") was present in the retrieved metadata.

<sup>34</sup>CourtListener full-text RECAP search for the exact phrase "RNC Services, Inc", queried via <https://www.courtlistener.com/api/rest/v4/search/?q=%22RNC+Services%2C+Inc%22&format=json>, returned "count":0. Google News RSS search (<https://news.google.com/rss/search?q=%22RNC+Services%22>) returned no relevant results (only an unrelated 2021 NOAA Coast Survey article matched incidentally).

3. Search the **Washington State Courts case index** (not covered by CourtListener) and the **Washington Secretary of State corporate registry** for “RNC Services, Inc.” directly, since state-level filings and state business registrations are outside the tools used in this pass.
4. If “RNC Services” turns out to be a real party, re-run a targeted CourtListener/news search combining that name with “Washington” and “racketeering” specifically (rather than “RICO”), since news coverage often uses the lay term.

## **Footnotes**